For long, mythological dramas and stories based on Hindu gods have ruled Indian television. Doordarshan enjoyed its highest viewership when it re-telecast two of its most popular shows, *Mahabharat* (1988-1990) and *Ramayan* (1987-1988), during the nationwide lockdown in 2020. Bollywood is now slowly following suit and turning to Indian epics. Reportedly, Nitesh Tiwari of *Dangal* (2016) and *Chhichhore* (2019) fame plans to direct *Ramayana* with Hrithik Roshan and Ranbir Kapoor in lead roles, Shekhar Kapur is making a series based on author Amish Tripathi's popular *Shiva* trilogy, and Akshay Kumar plays Lord Shiva in part two of *Oh My God*. In another recently released film, *Ram Setu*, Akshay Kumar is seen as an archaeologist who doesn't just have to prove the divine origins of the Ram Setu bridge but also saves it from destructive forces.

That's not all. Deepika Padukone is reportedly interested in producing a film on Draupadi, and *Uri* (2019) filmmaker Aditya Dhar's passion project, *The Immortal Ashwatthama*, is also in the works. However, with sections of society thundering over 'wrongful' portrayals and the need to 'protect' faith, an atmosphere of unease has engulfed the film industry. "Filmmakers will be reluctant and scared. There's too much ruckus, and creativity will be killed," says Kumar.

A DIFFERENT AGE?

Indian audiences, however, weren't always this sensitive to mythological or religion-based themes. In *Taqdeerwala* (1995), Kader Khan and Asrani played Yamraaj and Chitragupta, respectively, who come to Earth in search of a book but develop a weakness for ice-cream. Not so long ago, there were comedies like *God Tussi Great Ho* (2008), *OMG: Oh My God!* (2012) and *PK* (2014), which saw Aamir Khan play an alien who tries to find God and, in turn, exposes fraudulent godmen. Despite protests, *PK* went on to become one of the highest-grossing Hindi films of all time.

What's ironic is that T-Series, which has produced both *Thank God* and *Adipurush* and which had started out decades ago as an audio cassette company with a rich catalogue of devotional songs as its main source of revenue, is now being accused of insulting Hinduism. "No producer or filmmaker sets out to hurt religious or cultural sentiments, that would be counter-productive," says Bhushan Kumar, the owner of T-Series. "The idea is to revisit our rich history and present these characters in a larger-than-life yet human manner. Cinema goes hand-in-hand with creative liberty. So, one must approach it keeping that in mind."

Amish Tripathi, whose latest book, *War of Lanka*, looks at the battle between Ram and Ravan, was of a similar opinion in a recent interview. Speaking to INDIA TODAY TV, he talked about how Valmiki's *Ramayana* offered a "more nuanced take" on Ravan compared to the *Ramcharitmanas* and the *Puranas*. "Stories reflect the age they were written in, and interpretations differ with age," he said. "India is a free country and you have the right to put your point of view across and disagree; debate takes place in a respectful manner, without violence."

Despite the criticism and legal notices coming his way, Bhushan Kumar remains undeterred and convinced that Indian moviegoers will enjoy big-scale epics, especially the young audience. Raut, too, believes that films like *Adipurush* will encourage others to look at Indian epics for creative inspiration. "The entire idea behind making *Adipurush* is to tell the story in a way that it can be conveyed to the younger generation, which is consuming content at a global level, watching DC, Marvel [movies], *Harry Potter* and *Lord of the Rings*," says Raut. "I intend to create content that tells these youngsters—not just from India but the rest of the world—about the great history of our nation."

With an extensive team of VFX artists striving to bring to theatres one of India's most expensive films, Raut hopes that *Adipurush* will leave viewers satisfied, not offended. Hindu gods and mythology continue to inspire Indian filmmakers, but it remains to be seen whether the film industry will be able to defend creativity against the rising tide of hate and intolerance. ■

IN THE PIPELINE

↘ ADIPURUSH
Director: Om Raut

Made on a Rs 500 crore budget, the film features Prabhas as Raghav, who takes on Lankesh, played by Saif Ali Khan

↘ SHAAKUNTALAM
Director: Gunasekhar

Based on the iconic Kalidas play, the movie stars Samantha Ruth Prabhu as Shakuntala and Dev Mohan as Dushyanta, the king of Puru dynasty





↘ RAMAYANA
Director: Nitesh Tiwari

Dangal (2016) filmmaker revisits Ramayana with Hrithik Roshan and Ranbir Kapoor reportedly in the lead roles